

Air, Air, Everywhere

by Tangihoro Fitzgerald

If you stand outside and close your eyes, what can you feel? You might feel the warmth of sunshine. You might feel the damp coldness of fog. Or you might feel the wetness of rain. If it's a breezy day, you'll probably feel another thing: the air.



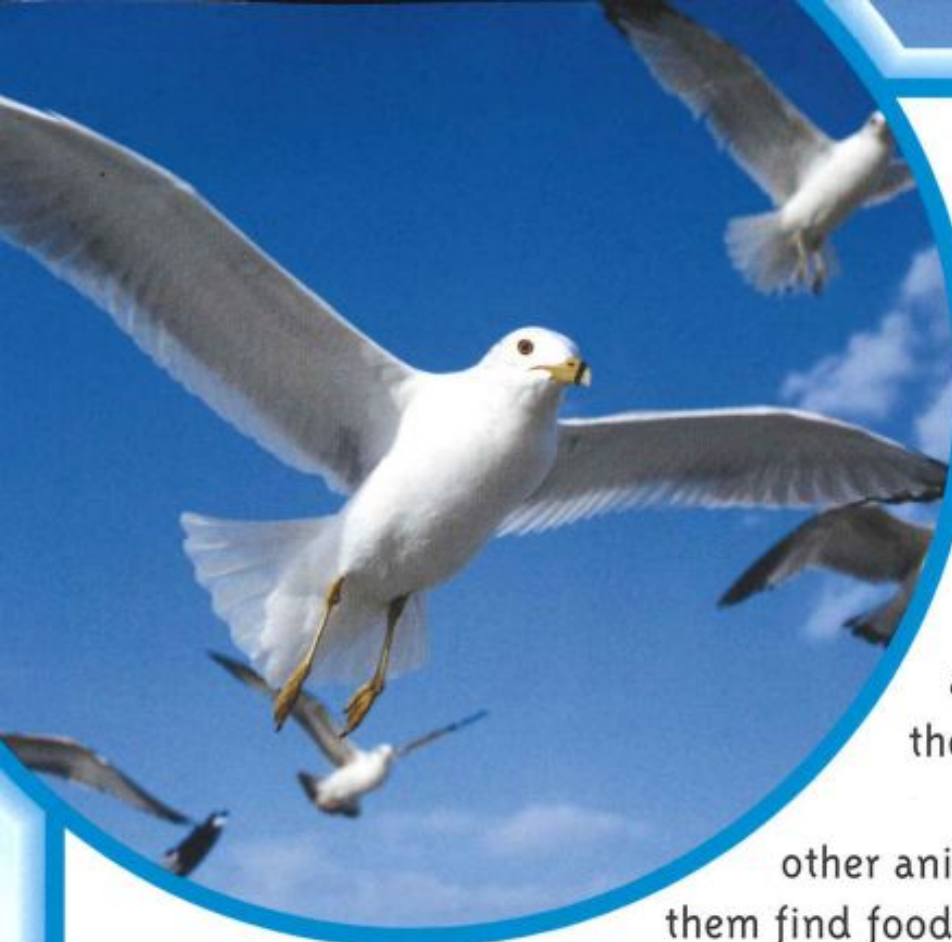
We don't often notice the air because we can't see it — but we can tell it's there if it's moving. We can feel moving air, and we can hear it. Breezes, gusts, winds, and gales are all just moving air. If you enjoy the wind rustling your hair, you can thank moving air. If you love a cool breeze on a warm afternoon, you can thank moving air. And if you feel a thrill when your kite swoops overhead, you can thank moving air for that, too.

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People have found lots of ways to use moving air. When we hang washing on a clothes line, moving air helps to dry it. That's why things dry quickly on a windy day. Also, moving air makes flags flutter. And if you fan yourself on a hot day, you move the air and create a little breeze that cools you off. Can you think of other ways in which people use moving air?



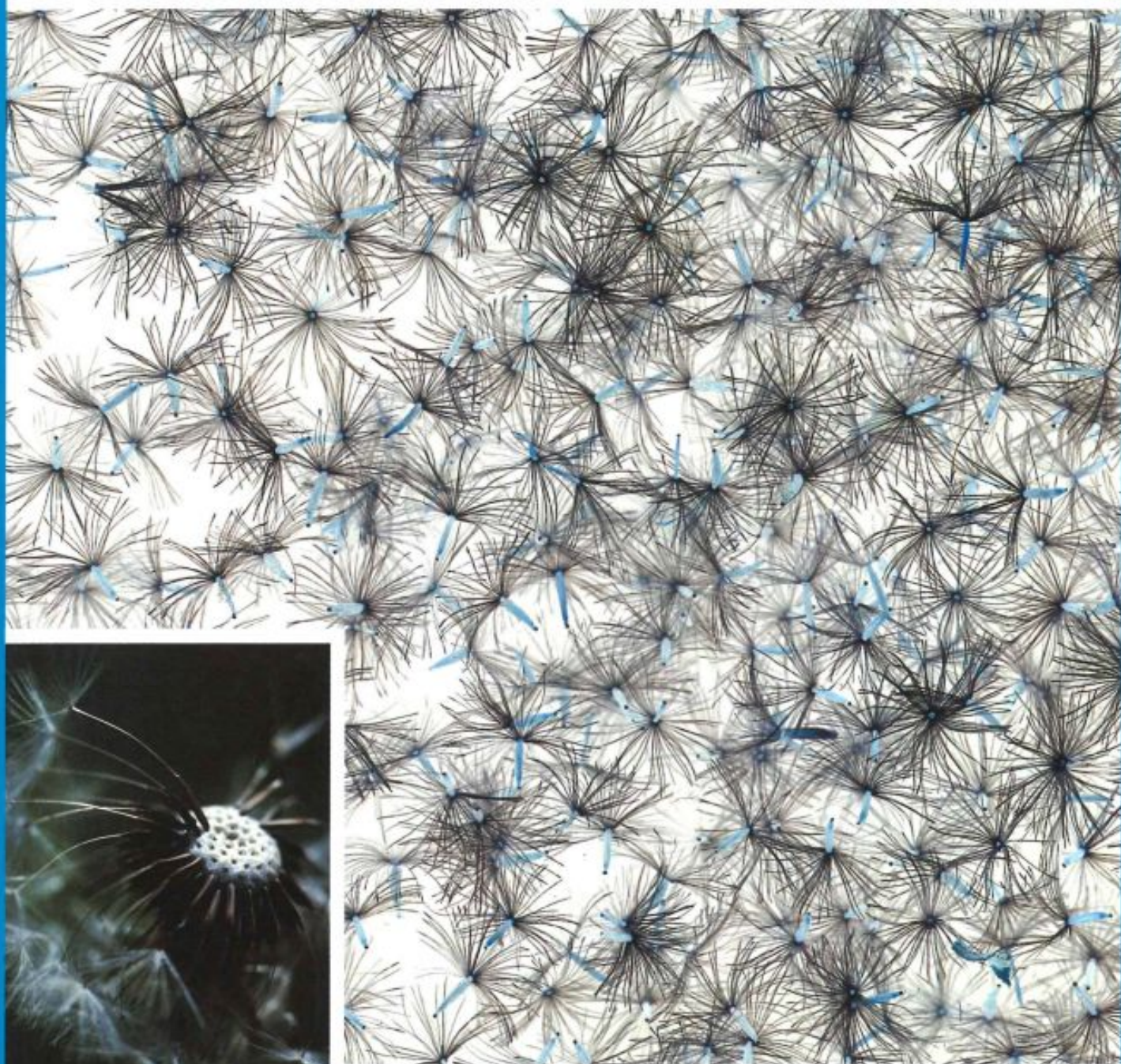


All sorts of other living things use moving air, too. Many birds can glide on the wind by holding their wings out wide. They only have to flap them now and then. That saves them lots of hard work.

Dogs, bears, and many other animals use smell to help them find food. Breezes carry smells from place to place. On a windy day, a lion can smell a gazelle that's a long way away. Of course, if the air is moving in the opposite direction, the gazelle will smell the lion!



Some plants use moving air to scatter their seeds. Have you ever blown on the fluffy head of a dandelion? Lots of little, furry "parachutes" fly into the air. Each one carries a small seed. On a windy day, a dandelion seed may be blown many kilometres. This means that the seed might settle and grow in a new area.



The wind helps living things in lots of ways. In fact, it's pretty amazing for something you can't even see!